and unchallenged. Udhayanidhi has been allotted the additional portfolio of planning and development, which enables him to get a synoptic view of governance across departments.

Stalin also reinducted into the cabinet V. Senthilbalaji, who had resigned after his arrest by the Enforcement Directorate on June 14 in a cash-for-jobs scam that took place when he was transport minister (2011-2015) in the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) government. The Supreme Court had granted him bail on September 26. New faces like Dr Govi Chezhian, R. Rajendran and S.M. Nasar have been inducted too, while ministers T. Mano Thangaraj (milk & dairy development), Gingee K.S. Masthan (minorities welfare and non-resident Tamils welfare) and K. Ramachandran (tourism) have been dropped from the council of ministers. The portfolios of several ministers were shuffled too. A cabinet reshuffle had been on the cards for a while. Analysts say Stalin wanted to "reward" Senthilbalaji for his loyalty—though he had defected from the rival AIADMK only in 2018—and decided to wait until he came out on bail.

In the DMK's present term in office (2021-), some veterans who have found it challenging to adapt to the changing ways in the party had feared they may be dropped from the cabinet. The Opposition and the media have levelled corruption charges against some others. "Stalin has spared them all and has, instead, sacked lesser elements, with the intent of sending out a message that the errant won't be spared," says political commentator N. Sathiya Moorthy.

What does Udhayanidhi bring to the table? His informal attire—the film star-politician is often in jeans and a T-shirt—and casual manner of speaking on political platforms have helped him connect instantly with the younger generation. Experts feel that will go from being an element of mere cosmetic freshness to be a harbinger of actual generational change down the leadership ranks. Udhayanidhi will take the lead in prepping a platoon of young generals for 2026. That might affect stalwarts from his grandfather's days, like Durai Murugan and K.N. Nehru. He will also have a say in seat allocation for DMK leaders, if not in seat-sharing talks with allies. Inevitably, a new group of loyalists will gather around him. Some senior DMK leaders began as associates of Stalin in the 1970s and were entrusted with local party responsibilities. Back in the day, Karunanidhi facilitated that process. Stalin is now doing the same.

Yet, there is a difference between father and son. "Stalin is an experienced partyman, politician and administrator. Udhayanidhi did not have to wait or evolve with time. He is the first leader in the DMK's history who has climbed the ladders of power without corresponding experience or work in the field," explains political analyst Ramu Manivannan, speaking of "sudden responsibility and the accompanying power". Also, in the long run, the party has to strike a balance between him and Karunanidhi's daughter and Thoothukkudi MP Kanimozhi so that they don't emerge as competing centres of power.

While anti-incumbency is a constant challenge, charges of 'dynastic politics' do not bother voters in Tamil Nadu much. The BJP will kick up dust

UDHAYANIDHI MAY BE JUST THE START. THE EMERGENCE OF ACTOR VIJAY IS A BIG CHALLENGE, AND THE DMK CAN'T AFFORD TO MEET IT WITH A GREYING POSSE

UDHAYANIDHI'S JOURNEY

- Born on November 27, 1977; attends Don Bosco school, Loyola College, Chennai
- Turns film producer with *Kuruvi* (2008); his Red Giant Movies production house is influential in the film industry
- Debuts as lead actor in *Oru Kal Oru Kannadi* (2012), wins Filmfare award for best male debut; acts in 16 more films, his latest being *Maamannan* (2023)
- Appointed secretary of DMK's youth wing in 2019; extensively campaigns for party before the Lok Sabha polls
- Wins from the Chepauk-Thiruvallikeni constituency in Chennai in the 2021 assembly election
- Appointed minister of youth welfare and sports development in December 2022



Udhayanidhi with M.K. Stalin

- In September 2023, Udhayanidhi compares Sanatana Dharma to "dengue" and "malaria" and calls for its "eradication" as it was against "social justice and equality". BJP castigates him for the remarks
- In March 2024, Supreme Court says he abused his free speech rights
- Elevated as Tamil Nadu's deputy chief minister on September 29